

Afternoon Discoveries

September 23, 2026



AMONG THE LETTERS

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Mystery, Thriller, Crime, Horror & Dark Fiction

Some mysteries begin with a body. Others begin with something less certain: an old recording that no longer behaves as it should, a missing person whose disappearance has never been explained, or a familiar house that suddenly feels occupied by something else.

Today's discoveries move between those possibilities. There are newly released mysteries, two unsettling stories available to read online, and a featured novel that brings crime fiction and folk horror into the same woods.

All selections were checked against the linked publisher, magazine, author, or literary organization's primary pages on September 23, 2026.

Featured Discovery

Crone - Keith Rosson

Eli Lamp has spent ten years searching for his missing daughter, Hannah. Once a detective, he now works as an enforcer for a local drug gang, living at the edge of the woods with his daughter's room preserved exactly as she left it. When the gang leader's son is murdered, Eli is offered a way out: find the killer and his debt will be forgiven.

Published yesterday, *Crone* brings together a damaged investigator, a violent criminal underworld, and something vengeful waiting in the forest. Rosson's premise gives the mystery a particularly difficult emotional centre. Eli isn't simply looking for answers to a new murder. Every clue threatens to

reopen the disappearance that destroyed his life. [Penguin](#)
[Random House](#)

[Visit the publisher page for Crone and read a sample](#)

The Discovery Desk

Murder at the Grand Alpine Hotel *- Lucy Foley*

A guest enters a gondola alive and reaches the top of a Swiss mountain dead. Somewhere among the wealthy visitors at the Grand Alpine Hotel is a murderer, and Miss Marple has arrived to observe them.

Lucy Foley's new Miss Marple novel places the familiar detective in a rather different social setting, exchanging village familiarity for an exclusive Alpine resort filled with competing interests and concealed grievances. The official Agatha Christie website has published an opening extract, offering readers a chance to encounter this new interpretation before committing to the book.

[Agatha Christie](#)

[Read the opening extract from Murder at the Grand Alpine Hotel](#)

Ticky-Tacky - *Kristi DeMeester*

Paula watches her neighbourhood from the window of her house at the end of a cul-de-sac. Her observations have become a private archive of videotapes, recording her neighbours' movements long after anyone else would have stopped paying attention.

In this new story, published by *The Dark*, Paula returns to an old recording and notices something that shouldn't be possible. DeMeester builds the unease through familiar objects: a kitchen window, a camcorder, an empty family home. What makes the story disturbing is how naturally its supernatural elements grow out of Paula's existing obsession with watching other people.

[The Dark Magazine](#)

[Read Ticky-Tacky in The Dark](#)

The Sherry Case - *H L Marsay*

Emma King travels to Andalusia hoping to find exceptional sherry for her family's wine business. Unfortunately, her terrible sense of direction leads her to a secluded vineyard, where she discovers a man's body instead.

Released today, the third Vineyard Mysteries novel trades the conventional country house for Spanish vineyards, local rivalries, and an investigation Emma has been specifically warned to avoid. When a friend becomes a suspect, she has another reason to interfere. The publisher has made the

opening chapter available online, and it establishes Emma's disorganised but observant character before she has even reached her hotel.

[Tule Publishing Group](#)

[Read the opening chapter of The Sherry Case](#)

The Red Veil **- *Daniel Roop***

After leaving the military, Sorrel travels to Wyoming to visit Luke, an old friend whose family has secrets of its own. What initially appears to be an opportunity to reconnect develops into an encounter with the supernatural and a family history that is considerably stranger than Sorrel expects.

Published in the September issue of *Nightmare*, Roop's story has room to develop its characters before revealing the full extent of its horror. Its interest lies partly in the relationship between two people carrying different kinds of experience and partly in what happens when an ordinary visit becomes an introduction to a hidden responsibility. The complete story is available to read online.

[Nightmare Magazine](#)

[Read The Red Veil in Nightmare Magazine](#)

Thank you for reading today's free edition.

The complete edition continues with more new fiction, an international collection of impossible crimes, two essays about constructing suspense and horror, and a recently revived crime classic. Special Recommendations at the end return to two foundational works, both available to read without charge.

✓ Subscribed

Special Recommendations can be found near the bottom of the article.

More From the Discovery Desk

Incarnate - *Alma Katsu*

Dorothy Wagner wants the kind of attention she has never managed to attract herself. Working for a company developing deepfake technology, she secretly creates Isabella, a beautiful digital personality whose following grows beyond anything Dorothy could have imagined.

Katsu's new novel, published September 22, reworks *The Picture of Dorian Gray* for an age in which people can manufacture the face the world sees. The central horror isn't simply that Isabella becomes famous. It is Dorothy's growing dependence on a creation she cannot safely acknowledge as her own. The publisher's page includes a sample.

Penguin Random House

[Visit the publisher page for Incarnate](#)

All the Crime in the World **- Edited by Gigi Pandian and Tom Mead**

The locked-room mystery has always depended on an intriguing contradiction: the evidence says a crime occurred, but the circumstances seem to make it impossible.

Editors Gigi Pandian and Tom Mead have gathered fourteen original impossible-crime stories from writers around the world. The collection draws on the form's traditional pleasures while changing the settings, cultures, and assumptions surrounding each puzzle. For readers who enjoy testing a proposed solution against the clues on the page, an anthology offers something a novel cannot: fourteen separate chances to be deceived fairly.

Crippen & Landru, Publishers

Explore All the Crime in the World on the publisher's website

The Boy the Bhoot Loved **- Fatima Taqvi**

Bisma accompanies her mother to clean a wealthy man's house, a place burdened by rumours and childhood stories. It is an uncomfortable assignment even before the possibility of something supernatural begins to intrude.

This September story from *The Dark* draws much of its tension from the circumstances that bring Bisma into the house in the first place. Her mother needs the work, the man who owns the property holds a different kind of power, and Bisma has very little control over where she is expected to go. The supernatural elements enter a situation that is already

unsettling.

[The Dark Magazine](#)

[Read The Boy the Bhoot Loved in The Dark](#)

We Chase Shadows **- Richard Osman**

A body appears on the steps of a private villa in the Italian hills. Beside it is a threatening note signed by an unknown man, and a new client wants Amy, Rosie, and Steve to discover who left it.

Osman's latest *We Solve Murders* novel, released September 15, gives the trio their first proper case together. The investigation extends beyond Italy as suspects emerge in several locations, and their client's reluctance to involve the police provides an early complication. This is a mystery with considerable geographical movement, but the central question is straightforward: who wrote the note, and why?

[Penguin Random House](#)

[Visit the publisher page for We Chase Shadows](#)

Crimson in Quietus **- Eugen Bacon**

Muso'mi is a scientist who studies sound in a world where it can be manipulated as a tangible force. When a friend disappears

after discovering a hidden truth, her research becomes the means of investigating something much more dangerous: a pattern of killings connected to harvested silence.

Bacon's novel occupies unusual territory between speculative fiction, murder mystery, and horror. Its investigator doesn't approach the crimes through conventional forensic methods. She follows clues through her understanding of sound, language, and silence. That makes the novel especially interesting for readers who enjoy mysteries built around an unfamiliar way of interpreting evidence.

Meerkat Press

[Discover *Crimson in Quietus* on the publisher's website](#)

Beyond the First Shelf

How to Write a Murder **- *Jessica Brody***

Seven mystery writers attend a conference at an isolated former monastery. An unwelcome literary agent arrives, someone is murdered, and a landslide prevents anyone from leaving. The suspects are people who spend their working lives inventing fictional crimes.

Published yesterday, Brody's novel has a second trick: it openly incorporates the structural techniques used to build a mystery while the reader attempts to solve one. In an essay published today, Brody explains the experiment behind that decision. Can

a writer reveal the machinery of a mystery and still conceal its solution? The novel and essay make an entertaining pair for anyone interested in how misdirection works.

[Penguin Random House](#)

[Visit the publisher page for How to Write a Murder](#)

[Read Jessica Brody's essay about constructing the novel](#)

The Narrative Potential of Sibling Rivalry in Thrillers **- Courtney Psak**

Two sisters can grow up in the same household and emerge with entirely different accounts of their childhood. Courtney Psak uses that possibility to examine the tension in her novel *The Aunt*, where Amy's estranged sister dies and the surviving sibling becomes a murder suspect.

Published September 22, Psak's essay considers how jealousy, perceived favouritism, financial difficulty, and unresolved family grievances can provide a thriller with more than an external threat. For writers, it offers a practical look at connecting a crime's immediate consequences to the relationships that existed long before it happened.

[CrimeReads](#)

[Read Courtney Psak's essay at CrimeReads](#)

Roadside Dread: Horror at the Diner - *Matthew Sorrento*

A diner promises warmth, food, and temporary shelter. It also places strangers together in a confined space, often beside a road that offers no obvious place to escape.

In this September essay from *Nightmare*, Matthew Sorrento traces how film noir, radio drama, monster films, and later horror productions have used the roadside diner to create suspense. His examples range from *Detour* and *The Blob* to more recent films. The piece is a useful reminder for writers that an ordinary setting can become threatening through the circumstances of its occupants rather than any change to the building itself.

Nightmare Magazine

[Read Roadside Dread: Horror at the Diner](#)

The Party at No. 5 - *Shelley Smith*

Elderly Mrs. Rampage lives alone in a large London house, surrounded by furniture and possessions accumulated over a lifetime. When she hires Mrs. Roach as a housekeeper and companion, the arrangement initially offers something both women need. Their difficulties begin when they discover how differently they believe the household should operate.

Originally published in 1954 and reissued in August through the British Library Crime Classics series, *The Party at No. 5* centres its tension on an unhappy domestic arrangement. Instead of

beginning with an elaborate crime scene, it examines how two increasingly resentful people become trapped in one another's lives.

[British Library Online Shop](#)

[Visit the British Library page for The Party at No. 5](#)

Special Recommendations

The Murders in the Rue Morgue **- *Edgar Allan Poe***

Before returning to another modern locked-room mystery, it is worth visiting the early detective story that helped establish so much of the form.

Poe introduces C. Auguste Dupin through an extended consideration of analytical thought before presenting a violent crime whose evidence appears contradictory. The pleasure of the story lies partly in observing how Dupin distinguishes useful details from the assumptions surrounding them. The Edgar Allan Poe Society of Baltimore provides the text of its original 1841 publication, making it possible to encounter the story in its earliest published form.

[Edgar Allan Poe Society of Baltimore](#)

[Read the original 1841 text of The Murders in the Rue Morgue](#)

The Yellow Wall-Paper - Charlotte Perkins Gilman

A woman confined to an upstairs room begins keeping a secret account of her surroundings. Her husband, a physician, believes rest will improve her condition, but isolation and the wallpaper surrounding her gradually become inseparable from the narrator's experience.

First published in 1892, Gilman's story remains an absorbing example of psychological horror told through an increasingly uncertain perspective. The U.S. National Library of Medicine hosts a digitized copy of the original magazine publication. Reading the story in that historical form adds another dimension to a work so concerned with who has the authority to describe another person's experience.

National Library of Medicine

[Read the original publication of The Yellow Wall-Paper](#)

Today's selections begin with investigators searching for answers and end with two stories that ask how much we can trust the evidence before us. Somewhere between those points, the mystery and horror genres frequently meet. Both can make an ordinary room, a familiar relationship, or a seemingly straightforward observation feel unexpectedly uncertain.

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*I hope you find something here that keeps you wandering among the letters for
a while.*

Take care!